relying on fictions and fantasies. That's how we got, for example, to Nazism and Stalinism. These were exceptionally powerful networks, held together by exceptionally deluded ideas. As George Orwell famously put it, ignorance is strength.

The fact that the Nazi and Stalinist regimes were founded on cruel fantasies and shameless lies did *not* make them historically exceptional, nor did it preordain them to collapse. Nazism and Stalinism were two of the strongest networks humans ever created. In late 1941 and early 1942, the Axis powers came within reach of winning the Second World War. Stalin eventually emerged as the victor of that war,[1] and in the 1950s and 1960s he and his heirs also had a reasonable chance of winning the Cold War. By the 1990s liberal democracies had gained the upper hand, but this now seems like a temporary victory. In the twenty-first century, some new totalitarian regime may well succeed where Hitler and Stalin failed, creating an all-powerful network that could prevent future generations from even attempting to expose its lies and fictions. We should not assume that delusional networks are doomed to failure. If we want to prevent their triumph, we will have to do the hard work ourselves.

THE NAIVE VIEW OF INFORMATION

It is difficult to appreciate the strength of delusional networks because of a broader misunderstanding about how big information networks – whether delusional or not – operate. This misunderstanding is encapsulated in something I call 'the naive view of information'. While fables like the myth of Phaethon and 'The Sorcerer's Apprentice' present an overly pessimistic view of individual human psychology, the naive view of information disseminates an overly optimistic view of large-scale human networks.

The naive view argues that by gathering and processing much more information than individuals can, big networks achieve a better understanding of medicine, physics, economics and numerous other fields, which makes the network not only powerful but also wise. For example, by gathering information on pathogens, pharmaceutical companies and health-care services can determine the true causes of many diseases, which enables them to develop more effective medicines and to make wiser decisions about their usage. This view posits that in sufficient quantities information